



**PSYC1003**

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## **Psychopathology & the birth of Psychotherapy**

### **Part 1: From Humours to Witchcraft**

**\*\*\*Content warning\*\*\***

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# Acknowledgement of Country

We acknowledge the tradition  
of custodianship & law of the  
Country on which the  
University of Sydney  
campuses stand. We pay our  
respects to those who have  
cared & continue to care for  
Country



## Readings (suggested)

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- Kemp, S. (2019). Mental disorder & mysticism in the late medieval world. *History of Psychology*, 22, 149-162
- Porter, R. (2002). *Madness: A Brief History*. Oxford University Press
- Tasca, C., Rapetti, M., Carta, M. G., & Fadda, B. (2012). Women & hysteria in the history of mental health. *Clinical Practice & Epidemiology In Mental Health: CP & EMH*, 8, 110

\*\*\*Exam Qs based on lecture material\*\*\*



## Outline for Parts 1-3

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### I. The concept & treatment of psychopathology

- Early conceptualisation & treatments
- Ancient & Middle Ages
- Clinical treatment in the US
- Mesmerism & hypnotism
- France & the rise of dynamic depth psychology
- The birth of *Psychotherapy*

## Learning outcomes (Parts 1-3)

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*After this lecture you should be able to:*

- Describe major historical explanations of psychopathology, including humoral, supernatural, somatic, & psychological accounts
- Describe how concepts of mental disorder have changed across historical periods
- Describe how assumptions about psychopathology have shaped treatment practices
- Describe the role of culture, politics, gender, & social values in defining mental illness

## A few opening words

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### **We still have a very poor understanding of psychopathology**

- History reveals ongoing debates about how distress & 'disorders' should be understood, classified, & treated
- The history of psychotherapy is typically viewed from a Western (Euro/Nth American) perspective
- Modern Psychology is only now catching up with diverse perspectives
- *We need to avoid oversimplifying historical accounts*



# The concept of psychopathology

**Psychopathology:** mental suffering, illness, disorder

- Folk conceptions: 'Madness', 'Insanity', 'Crazy'
- Changing views of psychopathology
- 'Disorders' come & go (eg. Nostalgia, Neurasthenia)
- Social changes & re-conceptualisation
- *Cultural concepts of distress* (DSM-5)
- *Why this matters: Our conceptualisation & understanding often determines treatment*





# I. The Humoural Theory

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- Ancient Greece: Bodily Humours & temperaments
- Hippocrates (460?-377?BCE) & Galen (130-200?ACE): **rejected supernatural explanations**
- ***'Natural' somatogenic explanations***
- **4 basic fluids (*humours*):** Blood, phlegm, yellow bile, black bile
- Classification of temperaments: Sanguine, Phlegmatic, Choleric, Melancholic types



# Temperaments



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## Sanguine (*blood*)

- Warm-hearted, optimistic

## Melancholic (*black bile*)

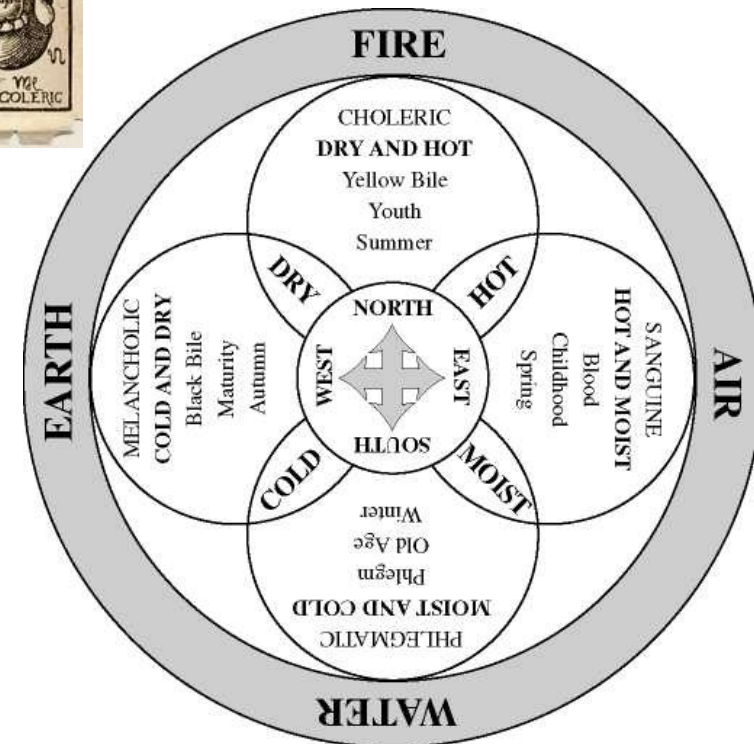
- Sad, depressed, anxious

## Choleric (*yellow bile*)

- Quick tempered, angry, assertive

## Phlegmatic (*phlegm*)

- Slow, lethargic, calm





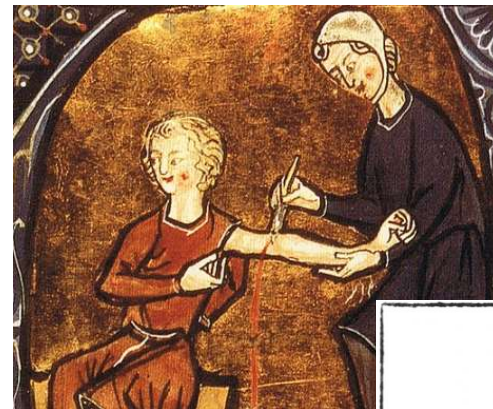
A medieval woodcut portraying the four temperaments and the elements traditionally associated with them: left — phlegmatic (water) and melancholic (earth); right — sanguine (air) and choleric (fire). (Zentralbibliothek Zurich, Ms. C 101)



# Causes of psychopathology & treatment

Psychological & physical problems arise from humoural 'fluid' imbalance

- ***Early treatments:***
- Lifestyle factors (diet, location)
- Phlebotomies (blood letting)
- Purging & emetics (vomiting)
- Leeches
- **NOTE: naturalistic causes & treatment**
- Persists until 1800s





## 2. Psychopathology & the middle ages

### 11<sup>th</sup>-15<sup>th</sup> C.: rise of supernatural explanations

#### Medieval explanations: *demonic possession & witchcraft*

- Insanity linked to perversity
  - Witch hunts
  - c.40-60,000 killed (Levack, 2016)
  - Mostly women
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- Note: continuity of humoural theory
  - **Natural causes coexist with diabolic causes**

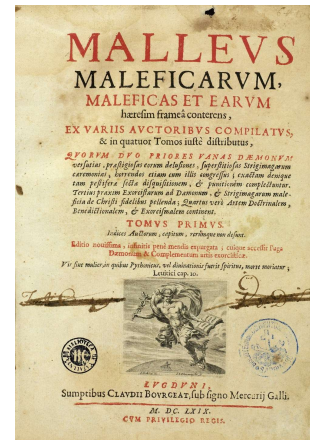


Fig. 114. DISRESPECTFUL CONDUCT OF THE DEVIL  
TO A FRIVOLOUS WOMAN  
*Der Ritter vom Turn.*

# Early 'diagnosis' & 'treatment'

## *Malleus Malificarum* (c.1486)

- Advice on detection, conviction & punishment of witches
- Salvation of immortal soul more important than comforts of physical body
- Exorcism: torture & physical punishment to rid the devil



# Witch hunts: A global problem in the 21st century





# The brain & trephination

- The brain could be disturbed or infiltrated by devils
- “...diabolic influence could mimic or aggravate a naturally caused disorder” (Kemp, 2019)
- Trephination: Drilling holes in the skull could release & remove evil spirits



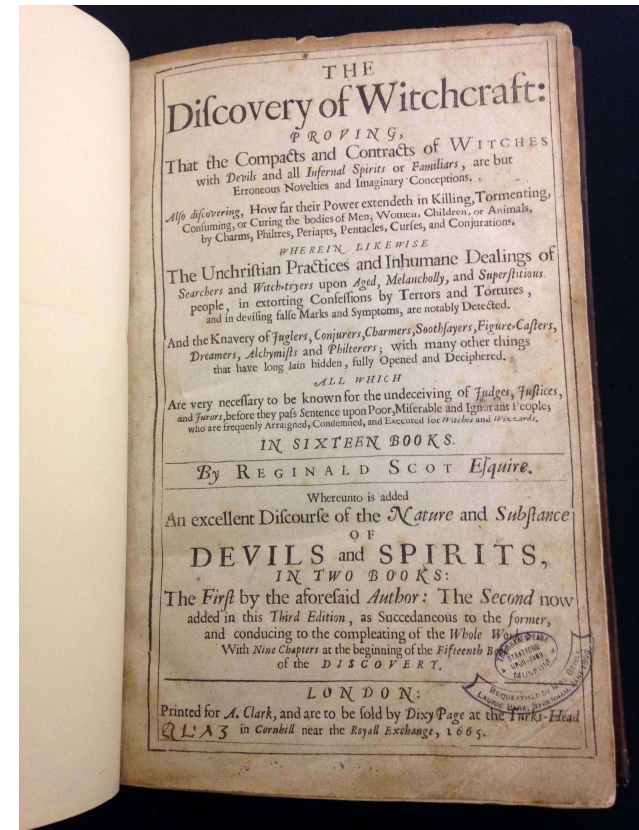
**Figure 1:** A depiction of trepanning from the painting *Cutting the Stone*



# Towards 'mental illness'

## Did everyone believe in demonic possession?

- **No!**
- Notable dissenters (eg. Reginald Scot; Johan Weyer)
- Argued that 'witches' were actually women with illnesses
- Scot's books burned on orders of King James I; Weyer forced into exile after book placed on *Index of Prohibited Books* by the Catholic Church





## Questions?

